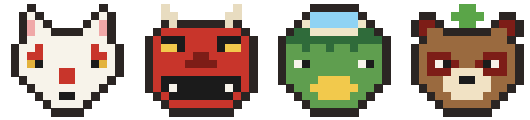


Yokai Fighters

Extended Game Design Document



This is the long-form companion to the 5-page readable GDD. It goes deeper into how the game feels, how every system works, and where the full game goes after the 5-week build. Anything marked **Full game** is a stretch goal outside the assessed build; everything else is must-ship. All numbers are first-pass targets that the test harness and playtests will tune.

1. Vision

1.1 The pitch

Yokai Fighters is a single-player 2.5D roguelite fighting game for PC. You play **Ryo**, an earnest, stubborn apprentice exorcist who binds yokai rather than destroying them, apologising to each one he seals into a talisman. Every yokai he binds lends him one of three abilities drawn from its power, so the yokai you choose to fight decide the fighter you become. At the end of every run waits the **Tanuki**, a shapeshifter that copies the move you have invested in most.

1.2 A run in practice

You pick **Kihon** controls, because motion inputs still feel foreign. The first duel is an apprentice Kitsune, slow to react and only half as dangerous, and on-screen prompts walk you through blocking, throwing, breaking a throw, meter, burst and one cancel. You win, the Kitsune is sealed into a paper talisman with an ink stroke, and Ryo murmurs: *"Forgive me, Kitsune. I'll give it back."* Three cards slide up. You take **Foxfire**.

At row 2 the map forks between an Oni and a Kappa. You want projectiles, so you avoid the grappler and fight the Oni, whose relentless pressure teaches you to block. At row 4 a cheerful travelling merchant offers you a choice: a free heal, or coins for a new ability. You are at 600 health, so you heal. As you leave, he grins: *"That Foxfire of yours... I'd love one."* You don't think much of it.

The Nine-Tailed Kitsune at row 5 reflects any special used twice in a row, so you learn to mix Foxfire with your anti-air instead of spamming it. It offers a cancel rule, **Fox Step**, which lets your specials cancel into a dash, and suddenly you're chasing your own fireballs across the screen. At the row-7 dojo you gamble on a training trial, land it on the second attempt, and Foxfire reaches Lv 3, evolving into **Piercing Foxfire**.

At the Tanuki's node the merchant drops his disguise. The rest-stop forecast had warned you: the Tanuki will copy Foxfire at Lv 3, without your evolution or modifiers. It throws plain Foxfire; yours pierce straight through it. You win with 140 health left, and a story card reveals why the Tanuki collects techniques. Next run, your talismans are blank again, all but one: Piercing Foxfire stays faintly inked, carried forward at Lv 2.

1.3 Design pillars

- 1 **Every upgrade changes how you fight.** Abilities change frame data, move properties and combo routes, not just damage. When Foxfire evolves into Piercing Foxfire, it cuts through the Kitsune's own projectiles, which changes how you win that matchup.
- 2 **Your fighter is yours.** The yokai you hunt shape the fighter you become: chase Kappa and you finish a grappler, chase Kitsune and you finish a zoner. Moves also change colour and effects as they level, so your build shows on screen.
- 3 **Every choice costs something.** Picking one path means skipping another yokai's powers. Slots are limited, a replaced move loses its levels, and dojos make you choose between healing and training.

- 4 **Easy to start, deep to master.** Kihon controls and a guided apprentice fight that teaches blocking, throws and throw breaks, meter, burst and a cancel let newcomers win fights in their first run. Kata motion inputs, frame traps and self-discovered cancel routes give veterans depth, and one-button specials never outperform manual inputs.
- 5 **The game answers your habits.** A strong build should never win on autopilot, meaning repeating one safe pattern without reading the opponent. Each elder yokai adds one rule twist that breaks a common habit: an elder Oni has armour on every special, so mashing jabs to interrupt it stops working, and a Nine-Tailed Kitsune reflects any special used twice in a row. The Tanuki copies your highest-level special at full level but never your modifiers or evolution: it steals the move, not the bond behind it, so the move you invested in is the one you must out-think.
- 6 **Readable, fair fights.** Every yokai telegraphs its attacks and has one habit to learn and punish. Yokai only react to what's on screen, never to your button presses directly, and harder yokai simply react faster, so every loss comes back to a decision the player made.

1.4 Audience, inspirations and build purpose

- **Primary audience:** roguelite players curious about fighting games. Kihon controls, a guided first fight, readable yokai habits and the rest-stop forecast exist for them.
- **Secondary audience:** fighting-game fans wanting deep solo content, served by the Kata precision bonus, cancel-rule depth, a frame-data toggle and a practice mode. If the scope gate cuts Kata, they are served by cancel depth alone, an accepted trade.
- **Inspirations:** Hades (run structure and story told across runs), Slay the Spire (drafting and branching maps), Street Fighter 6 (2.5D presentation and dual control schemes).
- **Build purpose:** the 5-week build is the capstone's assessed deliverable, a complete, polished one-act game, not a retail release. Success means a first-time player can finish a full run in 25–40 minutes and the copy rule works in every build.

1.5 Core loop

The map has 8 rows and you pick one node per row: 6 duels (including two elders) and 2 rest stops. Win a one-round duel, bind one of three abilities from that yokai, and move on. After row 8, the Tanuki waits. Health carries between duels; at zero, the run ends.

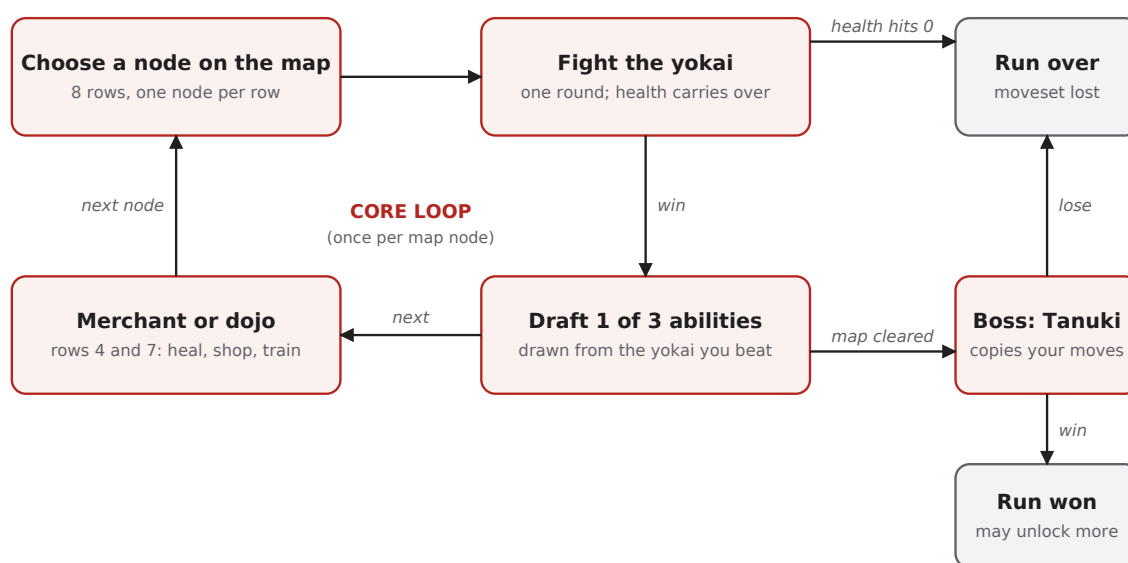


Figure 1. The core loop.

2. World and story

2.1 Setting, tone and art direction

A rural Japanese province at the end of autumn, folded into an illusion by the Tanuki. **Tone:** mischievous folklore with a melancholy edge, never horror. Yokai are tricksters and lonely spirits, not monsters, and every victory carries a small cost.

- **Look:** toon-shaded 3D with ink outlines and a muted ukiyo-e palette of persimmon, indigo, rice paper and pine. UI elements are paper talismans, brush strokes and red seals.
- **Stages:** one per yokai. A bamboo grove at dusk (Kitsune), a snowbound mountain shrine gate (Oni), a riverbank of floating lanterns (Kappa), and the Tanuki's tea house, whose paper screens flicker between seasons.
- **Music:** shamisen, shakuhachi and taiko, layered so intensity rises row by row. The Tanuki's theme borrows the merchant's cheerful melody and slowly detunes it.

2.2 Characters

Character	Role	Voice and motive
Ryo	Player character, apprentice exorcist	Earnest and stubborn. His master taught him that binding borrows a spirit's strength and a debt must be named, so he apologises to every yokai he binds.
Master Sōen	Ryo's teacher, seen only in the intro card	Patient and wry. Her rule, "name the debt", is the line the ending pays off.
The merchant / the Tanuki	Rest-stop trader; final boss	Cheerful, generous and quietly hungry. It collects techniques the way others collect teacups, and helps Ryo grow so there is more to steal.
The yokai	Opponents and sources of power	Real spirits trapped in the illusion and made to fight again each loop, which is why Ryo's apologies matter.

2.3 Story structure

The story is delivered through short cards, one or two sentences each, so it never interrupts the run for long. Story progress has its own save flag, independent of unlocks, and there is no post-game mode.

When	Card
First run, before row 1	Intro: Master Sōen's rule, "name the debt".
Every binding	Ryo's templated apology: "Forgive me, {yokai}. I'll give it back."
Row 4, merchant still disguised	"That {move} of yours... I'd love one." (templated to the current copy target)
First loss	Wake-up card: the Tanuki names the move it would have stolen, teaching the copy rule.
Later losses	Wake-up variants by row reached and by which yokai won.
Every run that reaches the boss	The merchant drops his disguise at the Tanuki's node.
Win 1	Why the Tanuki collects techniques.
Win 2	The Tanuki points out that Ryo's talismans are cages too.
Win 3 (ending)	Ryo binds the Tanuki and releases every yokai, his own included: "I said I'd give it back."

2.4 Sample cards

First loss. "You fall in the tea house, and the paper screens fold shut. Somewhere a cheerful voice says: 'Shame about that Foxfire. I'd have taken good care of it.' You wake at the province's edge. Your talismans are blank, all but one."

Win 2. "'You keep them in paper, I keep them in my sleeves,' the Tanuki laughs. 'Which of us is the collector, little exorcist?' Ryo has no answer yet."

3. Combat

3.1 Presentation: 2.5D

Built in Godot 4 (.NET) with C#. Fighters and stages are 3D models, but every rule happens on a flat 2D plane, as Street Fighter has done since SF4. A perspective camera with a narrow field of view keeps spacing easy to read while bodies and stages still look solid.

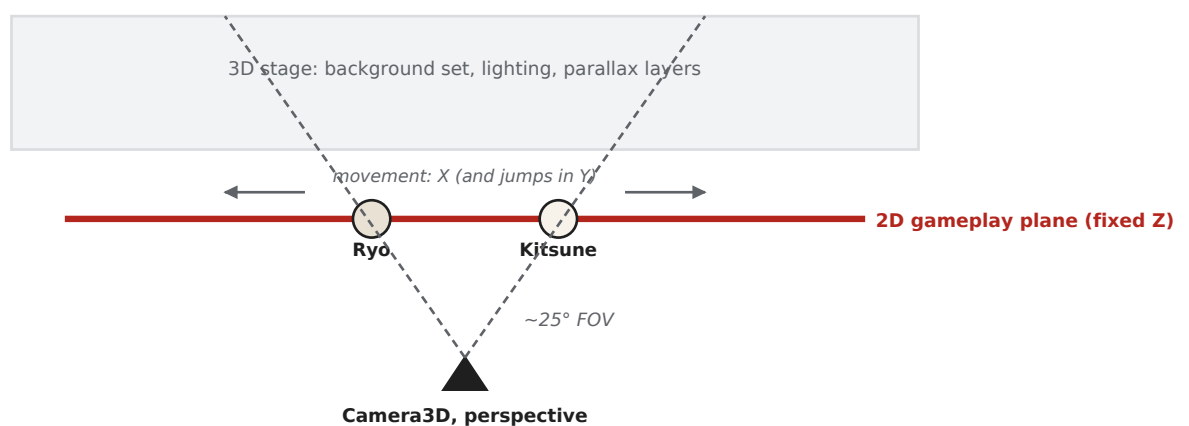


Figure 2. Top-down sketch: gameplay locked to a plane in front of a 3D stage.

3.2 Fight basics

Fights are one round at 60 frames per second. Ryo has 1,000 health, which carries across the whole run.

System	Rule (first-pass target)
Movement	Walk crosses the screen in about 2.5 seconds; dash 18 frames; jump 40 frames of airtime.
Blocking	Hold back. Lows must be blocked crouching (the Oni Quake hits low).
Throws	Generic: attacker plays a grab clip and the defender a standard knockdown. Startup 5, break window 7 frames by pressing throw. 120 damage.
Meter	Three bars of 100. +6 per hit landed, +3 per hit blocked or taken. An EX special costs 1 bar.
Burst	Once per fight. Breaks a combo with 20 invulnerable frames; costs all current meter.
Counterhits	Hitting an opponent mid-attack deals +20% damage and +6 frames of hitstun.

Ryo's normals (startup / active / recovery, damage):

Normal	Frames	Damage	Use
Light punch	4 / 2 / 7	30	Fastest button; interrupts pressure
Medium punch	6 / 3 / 12	50	Mid-range poke
Heavy punch	10 / 4 / 20	80	Big punish; anti-air if timed early
Light kick	5 / 2 / 9	30	Quick low
Medium kick	7 / 3 / 14	55	Longest-range poke
Heavy kick	12 / 4 / 22	90	Knockdown

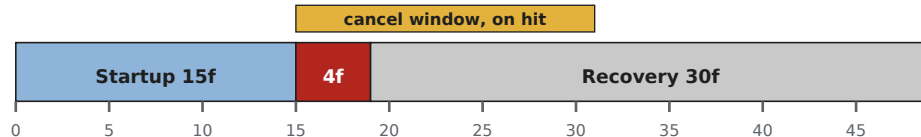
3.3 Control schemes

Scheme	Specials	Damage	For
Kata ("form")	Six buttons and motion inputs: ↓↘→ (slot A), →↓↘ (B), ↓↙← (C), ↓↓ (D)	100%, +10% precision bonus on motion-input specials	Players who want execution
Kihon ("basics")	Six buttons plus a Special button: neutral (A), forward (B), back (C), down (D)	100%	Newcomers

Combos and cancels work the same in both schemes. Kata is the first cut at the week-1 scope gate if the schedule slips; Kihon is never cut.

3.4 Frame data

Every move has startup (before it can hit), active (when it can hit) and recovery (when you are stuck finishing it). Clip Matcher picks each move's animation clip first, and Movesmith then writes frame data from that clip's real timing, so what you see always matches what the game resolves. A debug overlay draws hitboxes for the daily spot-check.



Foxfire, Lv 1 (first-pass targets): 15 startup, 4 active, 30 recovery. Gold marks the window where a cancel rule can chain.

Figure 3. Frame data for Foxfire at Lv 1.

3.5 Cancels

A **cancel** skips a move's recovery by starting another the instant the first hits, so the two combo. Ryo can't cancel anything at the start of a run; cancel rules, offered only by elders, add specific paths. Each move can be cancelled into once per combo, so stacked rules never loop.

- **Oni Chain** (heavy normals cancel into specials): heavy punch → Iron-Club Charge, a 190-damage punish.
- **Fox Step** (specials cancel into dash): Foxfire → dash → light punch as the flame connects, keeping pressure on a zoner.
- **Undertow** (successful throws cancel into a special): River Grab → Shell Spin while the opponent is still rising.

3.6 The fight screen

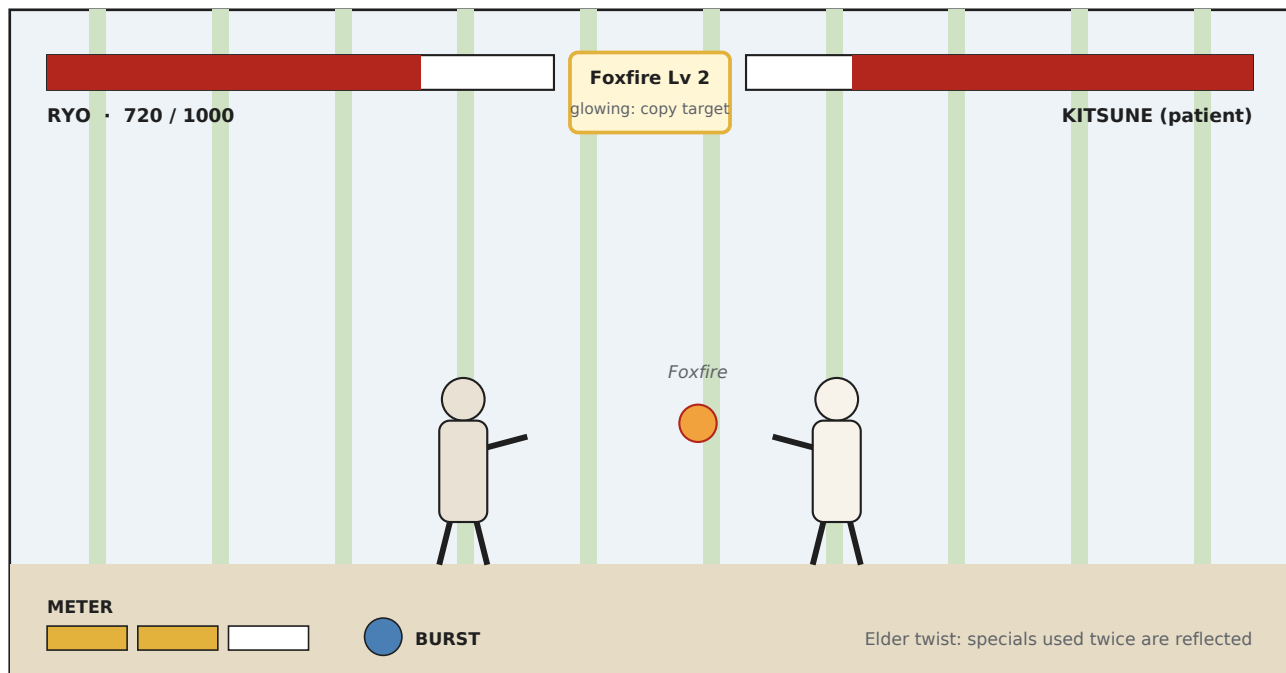


Figure 4. Fight HUD mockup: health, meter, burst, the glowing copy target and the elder twist reminder.

3.7 Game feel

Hits must feel heavy even with pre-bought animation, so most of the feel comes from timing, camera and sound layered on top.

Feel lever	Rule
Hitstop	Light 6 frames, medium 9, heavy 12; counterhits add 4. Both fighters freeze, selling the impact.
Screen shake	Heavy hits and EX specials only; 2-4 pixels for 6 frames. Never on light hits.
Round-ending blow	30 frames at half speed, then the binding: an ink stroke seals the yokai into a paper talisman.
Hit sparks	Coloured by source: foxfire orange, oni red, kappa teal, Ryo's own ink black.
Sound	Every hit layers an impact thud with a short yokai sting, timed by Clip Matcher to the impact frame.
Camera	Slow push-in on the Tanuki's reveal and on the round-ending blow; otherwise steady, so spacing stays readable.

4. Abilities

4.1 Slots, levels and offers

- **Slots:** four special slots (two start filled with Ryo's starters), one modifier per special, and up to two cancel rules.
- **Levels belong to the move:** anything newly drafted starts at Lv 1. Drafting a special you own levels it up; at Lv 3 it evolves.
- **Offers:** after each duel, three cards from the yokai you beat. One is always an upgrade to a move you own, starters included.
- **Rarity:** rare means cancel rules and each yokai's second special, offered only by elders. Everything else is common.
- **Locks:** 12 of the 33 abilities start locked (marked ♦ below). Evolutions come with their special and are never locked.

4.2 Specials

Special	Source	Frames (S / A / R)	Dmg	Notes	Lv 3 evolution
Spirit Wave	Ryo starter	13 / — / 30	60	Projectile	Great Wave: absorbs one projectile
Rising Talisman	Ryo starter	5 / 8 / 28	90	Anti-air; invulnerable to air attacks on frames 1-5	Heaven Seal: launches for a follow-up
Foxfire	Kitsune, common	15 / 4 / 30	70	Slow projectile	Piercing Foxfire: passes through projectiles
Fox Mirage ♦	Kitsune, rare	18 / — / 10	0	Teleport behind the opponent	Mirage Feint: leaves a decoy that absorbs one hit
Iron-Club Charge	Oni, common	16 / 6 / 24	110	Forward charge with 1-hit armour	Crushing Charge: wall bounce
Oni Quake ♦	Oni, rare	22 / 5 / 26	90	Ground pound; hits low	Aftershock: a second quake 30 frames later
River Grab	Kappa, common	6 / 2 / 30	130	Command grab (generic throw)	Whirlpool Grab: +50% range
Shell Spin ♦	Kappa, rare	10 / 18 / 20	80	Spins through projectiles	Torrent Spin: travels forward, multi-hit

Lv 2 gives each special one tuning step chosen per move, such as 4 fewer recovery frames or +10% damage.

4.3 Modifiers

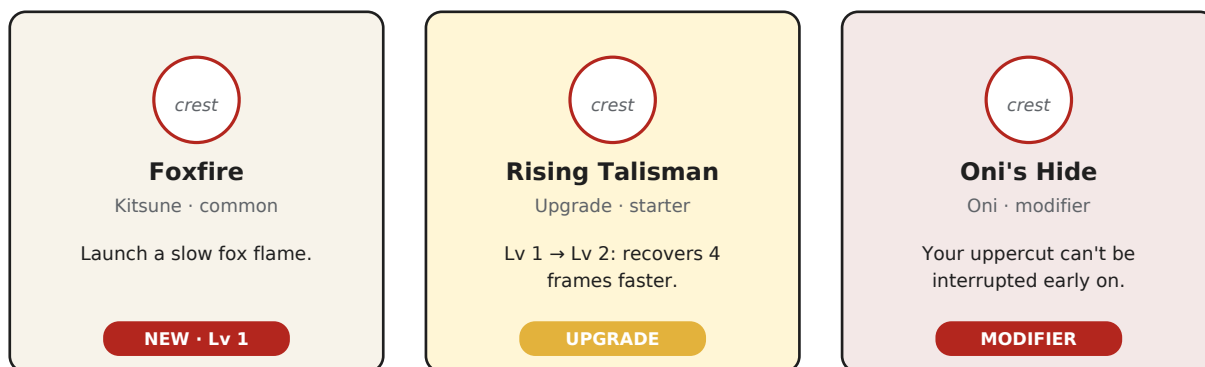
Modifiers are data-only: they attach to one special and change how it plays without new animation. If the balance gate cuts modifiers to 8, the six unlocked ones stay and locked ones drop to 2.

Modifier	Source	Effect on the special it's attached to
Will-o'-wisp	Kitsune	Projectiles travel 30% faster.
Fox's Patience	Kitsune	Builds 25% more meter on block.
Illusion Cloak ♦	Kitsune	The first use each round can't be counterhit.
Trickster's Angle ♦	Kitsune	Projectiles can be angled upward by holding up.
Ninefold Spark ♦	Kitsune	The EX version costs half a bar.
Oni's Hide	Oni	Armour on frames 1-5.
Iron Will	Oni	Can't be interrupted by projectiles.
Rage Ember ♦	Oni	+15% damage while Ryo is below 30% health.
Club Momentum ♦	Oni	Pushes the opponent 50% further toward the corner.
Brute Recovery ♦	Oni	4 fewer recovery frames on block.
Slippery Skin	Kappa	Throw-invulnerable during startup.
River Pull	Kappa	Pulls the opponent one step closer on hit.
Cucumber Gift ♦	Kappa	Heals 2% of max health on hit.
Sumo Stance ♦	Kappa	Hold the button to charge for +20% damage.

4.4 Cancel rules

Cancel rule	Offered by	Path
Fox Step	Nine-Tailed Kitsune	Specials cancel into a dash.
Oni Chain	Elder Oni	Heavy normals cancel into specials.
Undertow ♦	Elder Kappa	Successful throws cancel into a special.

4.5 The reward screen



Reward screen: three cards, one always an upgrade. Plain language first; frame data behind a toggle.

Figure 5. Reward screen mockup after beating a Kitsune.

5. Yokai

5.1 Profiles

In-game yokai are a deterministic C# state machine reading behaviour profiles that Habit Writer drafts. Each yokai has two temperaments, so repeat fights play differently, and one learnable habit that an attentive player can punish.

Yokai	Aggressive temperament	Patient temperament	Habit to punish	Elder twist
Kitsune (zoner)	Throws foxfire at mid range while advancing	Holds full screen and anti-airs jumps	Often jumps after a knockdown	Nine-Tailed Kitsune reflects any special used twice in a row
Oni (rushdown)	Dashes in constantly	Walks in and punishes whiffs with its charge	Dashes in after blocking a projectile	Elder Oni has armour on every special
Kappa (grappler)	Walks straight into throw range	Blocks, then throws after two blocked hits	Throws after blocking two hits in a row	Elder Kappa's throws can't be broken

Each elder's twist appears as an icon on its map node, a one-line intro card and a short callout the first time a player meets it.

5.2 Difficulty curve

Opponent	Reaction time	Damage per duel (newcomer / average)
Apprentice (row 1)	30 frames	110 / 80 (half damage)
Yokai (rows 2, 3, 6)	22 frames	220 / 160
Elder (rows 5, 8)	18 frames	280 / 200
Tanuki (boss)	15 frames	350 / 250

Across runs, each Tanuki win, up to three, makes yokai react 1 frame faster and pushes them toward their aggressive temperament, framed as the illusion growing stronger. Yokai only react to what is on screen, never to button presses directly.

5.3 The Tanuki

The Tanuki fights with Ryo's normals and starters plus one copied special. The copy rule is never cut and is built in week 2.

- 1 **Lock point:** when Ryo enters the Tanuki's node.

- 2 **Target:** his highest-level special in a slot, throws included. Sold and replaced moves don't count.
- 3 **Ties:** the one levelled most recently, then the lower slot.
- 4 **Strength:** at Ryo's level, but never his modifiers or evolution. It steals the move, not the bond, so an evolved Lv 3 move always beats its copy.
- 5 **Always defined:** the merchant won't release Ryo's last special.
- 6 **Visible all run:** the target's talisman glows in the HUD, and the rest-stop forecast names it. When shapeshifted, the Tanuki uses Ryo's model and clips, so copying needs no new animation.

6. The run

6.1 The map

Eight rows, one node per row. Rows 1–3, 5, 6 and 8 are duels; rows 5 and 8 always hold elders; row 4 is always the merchant; row 7 offers the merchant again or a dojo. Each node shows which yokai waits there, so choosing a path is choosing which powers you can earn.

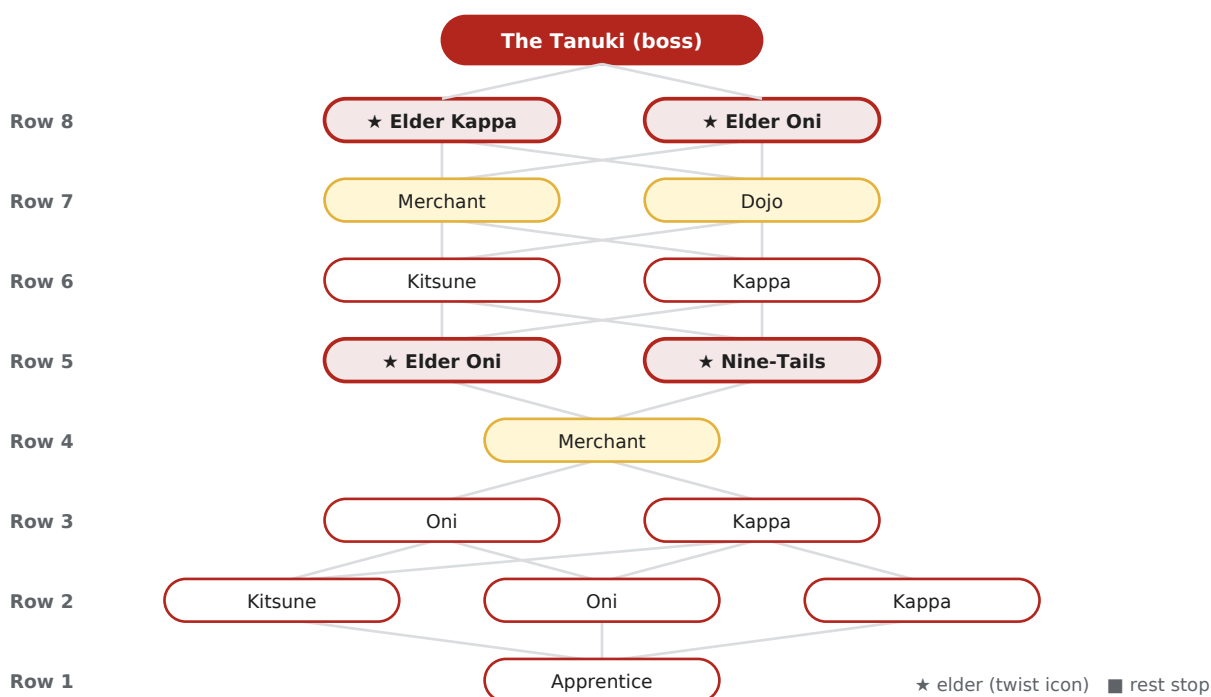


Figure 6. Map sketch for one run. Lines show which nodes connect.

6.2 Health and routes

Binding a yokai restores 50 health. The values below are tuned by the harness; the targets are fixed.

Route to the boss	Health on arrival
Newcomer: heal at row 4, rest at row 7	about 520
Newcomer: heal at row 4, train at row 7	about 370
Newcomer: shop at row 4, rest at row 7	about 270, short of the boss's cost
Average player: shop at row 4, train at row 7	about 490

Targets: across 200 simulated first runs by a newcomer-profile Kihon bot, calibrated against outside playtests, 50–70% reach the Tanuki and 40–60% of those beat it. At each rest stop, a **forecast** shows the Tanuki's copied move, its level and its expected cost from the player's own fights, so the risk is visible before choosing.

6.3 Rest stops

Stop	Choose one	Details
Merchant	A free heal (25%), or shopping	Shopping: common abilities from yokai you haven't bound this run (50 coins); release a binding to free a slot (40). Bought abilities appear in grey borrowed ink and never carry over. Never sells rares or cancel rules.
Dojo	Rest (heal 30%), or a training trial	A trial is a hand-authored, Kihon-completable sequence for one of your specials. It heals 15% either way and levels the special if landed within 3 attempts.

Sample trials: Spirit Wave: hit the dummy at mid range, then anti-air its jump with Rising Talisman. Iron-Club Charge: block the dummy's string, then punish with the charge before it recovers. River Grab: grab the dummy as it lands from a jump.

6.4 Coins

25 coins per duel on rows 1–6 and 50 for the row-5 elder; the row-8 elder pays a rare ability instead. That is about 75 coins at row 4 and 75 more by row 7, so every coin can be spent.

7. Between runs

Run reaches	Row 5 or earlier	Rows 6–8	The Tanuki	Tanuki win
Unlocks	0	1	2	4
Best special carried at Lv 2	No	Yes	Yes	Yes

- Unlocks are awarded at the end of a run, in a fixed order, so pushing on always beats dying on purpose. Twelve locked abilities take roughly 4–6 runs.
- The carry-over is the one exception to new moves starting at Lv 1. In the fiction, one talisman stays faintly inked.
- Story progress is saved separately, so the first reveal and the first-loss card never depend on unlocks.

8. Screens

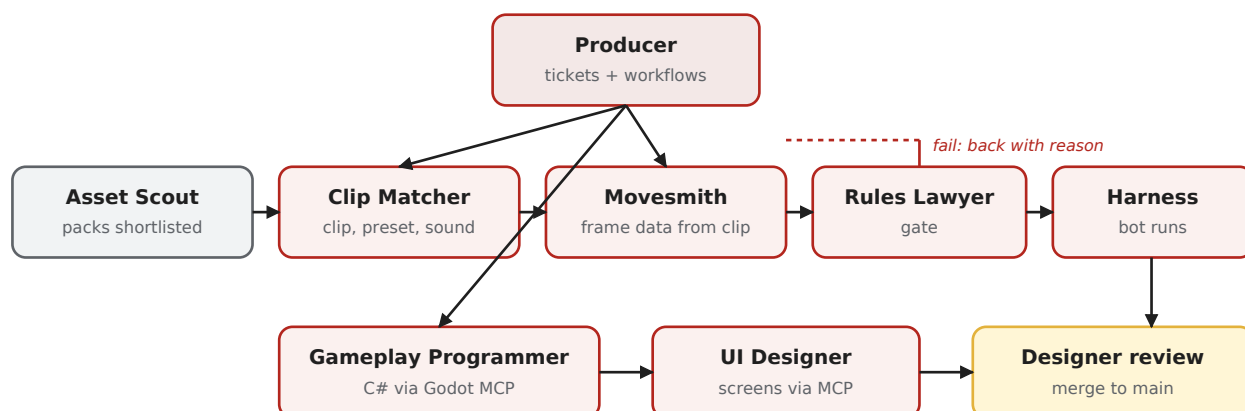
Screen	Purpose
Title	Start, continue, practice mode, settings.
Control select	Kata or Kihon, with one line explaining the precision bonus.
Map	Choose the next node; elder twist icons; the glowing copy-target talisman.
Fight HUD	Health, meter, burst, copy target, elder twist reminder (Figure 4).
Reward	Three cards; plain language first, frame data behind a toggle (Figure 5).
Rest stop	Merchant or dojo choice, with the Tanuki forecast.
Results	Depth reached, unlocks earned, the carried special.
Story card	Intro, wake-up, reveal and win cards.

Practice mode reuses the dojo scene with a training dummy, so it needs no new screen. Basic placeholder versions of every screen exist by the end of week 2.

9. AI architecture

The AI agents are **development tools**: an orchestrator leading three teams. None of them run in the shipped game.

Agent	Development role	What the player sees
Producer	Creates tickets for outstanding work and starts the matching workflow.	Balance fixes, like a Piercing Foxfire nerf, actually reach the game.
Movesmith	Writes the move list, then frame data from each matched clip, hitboxes, card text and trials.	Rewards that change how a move plays.
Habit Writer	Writes temperament profiles and all story-card text to the tone line.	Learnable yokai, and a story that names your own moves.
Rules Lawyer	Rejects content files that break the written rules, with a reason.	A Kappa never offers a projectile.
Sparring Partner	Reads whole-run bot results.	Difficulty that was measured, not assumed.
Asset Scout	Shortlists model, animation, sound and music packs.	Ryo and the yokai look and sound like one world.
Clip Matcher	Picks each clip first, then adds level presets and frame-timed sound.	Hits land, look and sound right on the frame.
Gameplay Programmer	Writes C# systems, fight AI and the test bot through the Godot MCP.	Every yokai fights; every number is tested.
UI Designer	Builds every screen and the HUD in Godot through the MCP.	Cards and meters stay readable mid-combo.



Data merges after schema, Rules Lawyer and harness checks; code merges only after designer approval.

Figure 7. How work flows between agents.

Content runs as a **pipeline with a gatekeeper**: Rules Lawyer returns broken drafts with a reason, and the harness checks trials, cancel loops and copied moves at runtime. Code runs a **closed build-and-test loop** through the MCP on its own branch and merges only with designer approval.

10. Technical strategy

10.1 Engine, assets and constraints

- **Engine:** Godot 4 (.NET) with C#. All assets are pre-bought and unified by a toon shader.
- **Week 1 go/no-go gate:** walk, heavy and throw clips must retarget onto each yokai without clipping tails, shell or club; a yokai that fails uses its folklore human guise.

- **Generic throws:** no paired throw animations anywhere, so any special, throws included, can be copied.
- **Constraint, a deterministic 60-tick loop:** animations are stepped by exact frames with *AnimationPlayer.Seek()*, and hitboxes are 2D rectangles in move data, not physics shapes. Frame data is exactly true, and whole-run bot tests are repeatable.
- **API: Claude**, with prompt caching, the Message Batches API for overnight content and web search for the Asset Scout.

10.2 What ships

Item	Count	Makeup
Specials / evolutions	8 / 8	2 starters + 2 per yokai; one evolution each, data-only with a visual preset
Modifiers / cancel rules	14 / 3	Data-only; cancel rules from elders only
Abilities	33	12 start locked: 3 specials, 8 modifiers, 1 cancel rule
Behaviour profiles	7	3 yokai × 2 temperaments + Tanuki
Screens / story cards	8 / ~20	See sections 8 and 2.3
Code tickets	85	Combat 20, AI 12, run 20, harness 10, UI 10, save 4, overlay and practice 3, pipeline 6

10.3 Token budget

Agent	Calls	Tokens per call (in + out)	Total
Producer	3 runs a day × 35 = 105	10,000 + 2,000	1,260,000
Movesmith	33 × 3 = 99	3,000 + 800	376,200
Rules Lawyer	33 × 3 = 99	4,000 + 300	425,700
Habit Writer	28 profile + 14 story = 42	4,000 + 1,500	231,000
Sparring Partner	4 weeks × 5 = 20	20,000 + 2,000	440,000
Asset Scout	45 searches	15,000 + 1,500	742,500
Clip Matcher	30 clip + 12 cue batches	6,000 + 2,000; 5,000 + 2,000	324,000
Gameplay Programmer	85 × 4 revisions × 3 turns = 1,020	18,000 avg + 3,000	21,420,000
UI Designer	8 × 5 revisions × 3 turns = 120	10,000 + 4,000	1,680,000
Total	1,592 calls	~26.9M; ceiling 40.3M with 50% contingency	

Spend is front-loaded: about 4.5M in week 1, 10M in week 2, 8M in week 3 and 2.2M in each polish week. The Programmer's context is modelled growing from about 10k to 25k tokens; a maintained codebase map keeps it down by pulling only relevant files. If a week runs over, simple tickets move to a smaller Claude model; Sparring Partner is protected. **Designer time:** 210 hours (6 a day, 7 days a week): about 60 code review, 60 playtesting, 35 rules, 25 spot-checks, 10 purchases and gate, 20 buffer, with code batched into one daily review queue.

10.4 Schedule and cut gates

Week	Milestone
1	Move list, retargeting gate, packs bought, open rules settled. Combat core, both schemes, AI framework, test bot. Scope gate.
2	33 abilities, 7 profiles, Tanuki and copy rule. Map, merchant, dojo and unlock logic with basic placeholder screens. Whole-run harness. First outside playtest.
3	Final screens and HUD, story cards, integration. Balance gate mid-week. Feature freeze.
4-5	Polish only: second outside playtest, balance, audio, effects, bug fixing.

- **Scope gate** (end of week 1, on actual velocity): cut Kata, then the meta-unlock layer (carry-over and story stay).
- **Balance gate** (mid-week 3, on harness and playtest data): modifiers 14 to 8, then dojo trials, then colour-only presets.
- **Never cut:** the copy rule, the merchant, Kihon, the harness and the story cards.

11. Full game: stretch goals

None of this is in the 5-week build. Each goal is described by what it adds to the feel of the game, then by what it would take.

Goal	What it adds to the feel	Rough cost
Evolution choices	A real decision at Lv 3: two evolutions per special	Low: +8 data-only evolutions and presets
Supers	A cinematic three-bar finisher with a camera push	High: new animation per fighter
Shrines	Risk, folklore and surprise between duels	Medium: writing plus one screen
Jorōgumo and Tengu	Two new archetypes and four new matchups	Medium-high per yokai
Acts 2 and 3	A longer journey with new regions and act bosses	High
Tetsu and Kaede	New starting kits that change how a run begins	High per character
Mastery	A reason to replay one character	Medium
Heat	Optional difficulty for players who have won	Low
Yūrei gauntlet	Fighting other players' winning builds	High: needs an online backend

11.1 Evolution choices

At Lv 3, each special offers a choice of two evolutions instead of one, such as Twin Foxfire (two hits) or Piercing Foxfire (passes through projectiles). The moment should feel like choosing a path on the map: a commitment you can see in the very next fight. The Tanuki still never copies either evolution.

11.2 Supers

A three-bar finisher per fighter, with the camera pushing in and the stage dimming to ink. Supers would make meter a bigger strategic resource, but each needs bespoke animation, which is why they are out of the 5-week build.

11.3 Shrines

Shrines would replace some duel nodes with moments of risk and folklore. One of three appears at random:

- **Offering shrine:** give up a move or 20% of your health for a random rare ability, never a cancel rule.
- **Folklore encounter:** a short choice from yokai legend. Bow to a kappa and it bows back, spilling the water from the dish on its head, so the next Kappa starts at 25% less health. Refuse and you gain 20 coins.
- **Cursed shrine:** a strong ability with a drawback, such as Oni's Fury: specials deal 20% more damage, but you can't block for a second after using one. The merchant removes curses, which ties shrines to the economy.

11.4 New yokai

Yokai	Archetype	How it fights	Elder twist (proposed)
Jorōgumo (spider woman)	Counter	Sets web traps and waits for you to attack; parries	Webs slow every dash
Tengu (mountain spirit)	Trickster	Wind dashes and feather teleports; punishes weak anti-airs	Teleports after every blocked hit

11.5 Acts 2 and 3

Two more regions, a mountain pass and the provincial capital, each with its own act boss, before the Tanuki becomes the final boss. The story's three win cards would spread across the acts, so each act ends on a beat.

11.6 New characters

Character	Base kit	Starting specials
Tetsu, a wandering monk	Slow, long-reaching heavies; a grappler at heart	A command grab and an armoured charge
Kaede, a shrine maiden	Fast, short-range normals; a trickster	A thrown talisman and a short teleport

Each character has their own normals, starting specials and a signature move pool weighted into their reward offers, while sharing universal rewards. Mastery is tracked per character and never carries over.

11.7 Mastery and Heat

Mastery: landing a move earns it mastery, which adds new evolutions and modifiers for that move to the reward pool. It adds options, never raw power. **Heat:** after a first win, optional modifiers make runs harder, such as yokai gaining meter twice as fast.

11.8 The Yūrei gauntlet

After the final boss, a gauntlet of three yūrei: ghostly copies of other players' winning builds, played back by their recorded habits. Ghosts are picked at random, but each must differ from your build and from each other, sharing at most two specials, where the pool allows. Because the fight loop is deterministic, ghost fights need no netcode, only an online store of builds and a leaderboard.

12. Risks and open questions

Risk	Mitigation
Purchased packs lack a clip for a planned move	The move becomes a mechanically equivalent one on an approved clip; no bespoke animation.
Retargeting clips onto non-human yokai fails	Week-1 go/no-go gate, with a fallback to the yokai's folklore human guise.
Agent-written code hides subtle bugs	Closed build-and-test loop, own branch, designer approval for every merge.
The bot misjudges newcomer difficulty	Bot calibrated against outside newcomer playtests at the end of weeks 2 and 4.
Week 1 or week 3 overruns	Scope gate and balance gate, with a fixed cut order and a never-cut list.

Open questions: the exact Lv 2 tuning step for each special; the asset spend; and whether practice mode should unlock trials for every special or only those you own.